
THE LAST
TRAIN
TO NOWHERE
SOME TICKETS ARE NEVER BOUGHT.
THEY ARE GIVEN.
H. R. B.

THE LAST TRAIN TO NOWHERE

A *Psychological Mystery Thriller*

H. R. B.

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CHAPTER 1

The Funeral

The smoke from Dadaji's funeral rose in a thin grey line and vanished into the evening sky. I watched it until my eyes burned. Around me, the men of Madhavgad stood with their heads bowed, their faces solemn in the orange light. Nobody spoke. Only the river kept talking, slow and tired, as if it had heard this story many times before.

I was twenty years old, and I had never felt so small.

Dadaji was not just my grandfather. For forty years he had been the station master of Madhavgad Junction, the man who decided when trains arrived and when they left. As a child, I believed he controlled time itself. Every evening he sat on the veranda with his tea, listened for the distant whistle, and said, without looking at any watch, "Right on time." He was never wrong.

Aai touched my shoulder. "Come, Harsh. It is getting dark."

"Five more minutes," I said.

She did not argue. She only stood beside me, her dupatta pulled tight around her shoulders, and we watched the last flames settle into embers.

By the time we reached home, the house was full of relatives. The air smelled of incense and boiled rice, and the rooms hummed with whispers. Everyone wanted to say something kind, but kindness is hard to hear when you are tired. I slipped away to the one room where nobody had gone yet: Dadaji's.

It was exactly as he had left it. The iron cot with its faded blue blanket. The steel glass on the table, still holding a ring of dried tea. On the wall hung a black-and-white photograph of the station, with Dadaji standing on the platform, young and straight-backed, one hand raised as if he were about to stop the whole world.

Under the cot sat a green tin trunk. I had seen it a hundred times and never once seen it opened.

The lock was not even closed.

Inside, the first thing I found was his old railway uniform, folded with sharp corners the way only he could fold it. Beneath it lay a brass lantern, a bundle of letters tied with a faded red thread, and a small object wrapped in a white handkerchief.

I unwrapped it slowly. It was a pocket watch, heavy and cold, with a dented brass cover. The hands had stopped at exactly 2:47. When I turned it over, I found four words engraved on the back in thin, careful letters:

For the one who follows.

I read them three times. They were cryptic, like a riddle with no question. Who was the one who follows? And follows what?

Then I noticed something else. A small yellow card was tucked inside the lid of the watch, so thin that I almost missed it. It was a railway ticket, the old kind, printed on stiff paper and punched with a tiny hole.

MADHAVGAD JN. to ANANTPUR ROAD. Night Express. Coach S4, Seat 41.

The date stamped on it was tomorrow's.

My heart began to beat harder. Dadaji had not left the house for over a month. His legs had grown too weak, and the

doctor had forbidden even the walk to the gate. So who had bought this ticket? And when?

I pulled out my phone and typed *Anantpur Road* into the map. The little blue circle spun for a moment, then returned a single line: *No results found.*

I tried again with the railway website, then a search engine, then three different spellings. Nothing. No station, no village, no town, not even a faded mention on a forum. As far as the whole internet was concerned, Anantpur Road did not exist.

"Harsh?"

I jumped. Aai stood at the door, holding a plate of food I did not want. Her eyes moved from my face to the open trunk, and something flickered across her expression, something quick and careful, there and gone before I could name it.

"I was just looking," I said. I closed my hand over the ticket. I do not know why. It felt like the first time in my life that I was keeping a secret from her.

"Eat something," she said softly. "Tomorrow will be a long day."

She left the plate on the table and went out. I stood listening to her footsteps fade, and the quiet of the room settled around me like dust.

I am an engineering student. I believe in logic, in cause and effect, in things that can be measured and explained. A ticket for a station that does not exist, bought by a man who could not walk, was not something logic could explain.

But Dadaji had never done anything without a reason.

I looked at the watch again, lying in my palm, silent for as long as I could remember. Then, as I stood there in the dim yellow light, it gave a single soft *tick*.

The hands did not move. The sound did not come again. But I knew what I had heard.

I put the watch in my pocket, folded the ticket into my wallet, and made my decision.

Tomorrow night, I would take the train.

CHAPTER 2

Platform Number Nine

The next evening, Madhavgad Junction was as bustling as ever. Porters in red shirts hurried past with suitcases balanced on their heads. A chai seller walked the length of the platform calling, "Garam chai, garam chai!" The loudspeaker crackled with announcements in Marathi, Hindi and English, each one slightly late, as if the voice were always chasing the trains.

Aai had walked with me to the gate. She carried a steel tiffin wrapped in newspaper, still warm. Inside were chapatis and potato curry, enough for three people.

"I am only going for one night," I told her.

"I know." She pressed the tiffin into my hands. Her eyes looked weary, but they were steady. "Harsh, your Dadaji told me something once. He said, if a ticket ever comes for you, do not ask who sent it. Ask where it leads."

I stared at her. "You knew about the ticket?"

"I knew he was waiting for something," she said. "I never knew what." She touched my cheek once, quickly, and let go. "Go. Do not miss your train."

I wanted to ask her a hundred questions. Instead, I picked up my bag and walked into the station.

The board above the ticket window listed every train of the night in glowing orange letters. Most had platform numbers beside them. At the bottom, in a different, older kind of lettering, I found it: *NIGHT EXPRESS, Platform 9.*

I asked a porter where Platform 9 was. He scratched his head.

"Nine? Nobody uses nine anymore, saheb. Go to the far end, past the water tank. Be careful, the stairs are old."

He was right about the stairs. They creaked under my feet like they were complaining. The far end of Madhavgad Junction was a different world: the lamps were dim, the paint was peeling in long grey curls, and half of the tin roof had rusted into lace. Everything about it was dilapidated, a vestige of the days when steam engines ruled these tracks. Weeds grew between the stones. A stray dog watched me from under a broken bench and did not bark.

The sign for Platform 9 hung by a single chain, swinging gently although there was no wind.

I checked my phone. 11:52 p.m. No signal.

I stood there alone, holding Dadaji's watch in one hand and the tiffin in the other, and for the first time I wondered if I was making a mistake. I could still turn back. I could still go home, sleep, wake up to ordinary life, and forget the ticket.

Then I heard it.

First a low hum in the rails, so faint that I felt it in my shoes before I heard it with my ears. Then a whistle, long and deep, nothing like the sharp electric horns of modern trains. It sounded like a voice calling a name.

The Night Express rolled out of the dark.

It was not like any train I had seen. The coaches were painted a deep, old green, with brass handles and windows glowing a soft yellow. A thin mist curled around the wheels. It slowed with a long, tired sigh and stopped so smoothly that the platform did not even shake.

A door opened in front of me. Coach S4.

A man stepped down. He wore a black coat with brass buttons and a cap pulled low, and he held a small brass lantern,

though the platform lamps were bright enough. His face was lined and calm, and his eyes were the colour of old tea.

“Ticket, please,” he said.

My hand shook a little as I handed it over. He studied it for a long moment, longer than any ticket examiner had ever studied anything. Then he looked up at me, and something in his expression softened.

“Seat forty-one,” he said quietly. “We have kept it empty for a very long time.”

“I am sorry?” I said. “What do you mean?”

But he had already stepped aside to let me in.

“Welcome aboard, Harsh,” he said. “I am Mr. Kulkarni.”

I froze with one foot on the step. I had not told him my name.

Before I could speak, the whistle sounded again, and the train gave a gentle jerk. I climbed in just as the platform began to slide away behind me. Through the window, I watched Madhavgad Junction shrink into the dark until its last light blinked out.

In my pocket, the brass watch ticked again.

CHAPTER 3

Strangers in Coach S4

Seat 41 was a window seat in the middle of the coach, with a worn green cushion and a small brass hook for hanging a bag. I sat down and let out a breath I did not know I had been holding.

The coach was warmer than I expected, and quieter. There were no vendors, no loud phone calls, no babies crying. Only the soft rhythm of the wheels, *tak-a-tak*, *tak-a-tak*, and the faint creak of old wood.

Four other passengers shared my section.

By the opposite window sat a young woman, perhaps twenty-four, in a black jacket with a notebook open on her knee. Her pen moved quickly, and her eyes moved even faster. Next to her, an elderly man with silver hair and round glasses was folding a newspaper into neat quarters. Across the aisle, a mother held her sleepy little boy against her shoulder. By the door sat a silent man in a grey shawl, with his face turned toward the dark glass.

"First time on this train?" the young woman asked, without looking up.

"Is it that obvious?"

"You looked at the ceiling lamp for ten seconds," she said. "Everyone who rides this train does that at first." She closed her notebook and offered a hand. "Meera. I write for a newspaper in Mumbai."

"Harsh. I am a student."

"What are you studying?"

"Engineering."

“A man of logic,” she said, and smiled, but it was a tired smile. “You will not enjoy this journey.”

The old man chuckled. “Do not frighten the boy, Meera. I am Fernandes. I taught mathematics for thirty-five years. Believe me, young man, nothing in this world is truly illogical. It is only logic we have not met yet.”

The mother nodded politely at us. “Kavita,” she said. “And this is Rohan.” The little boy opened one eye, studied me, and closed it again.

I laughed, and for a moment the strangeness of the night felt smaller. I unwrapped Aai’s tiffin and offered chapatis around. Mr. Fernandes accepted one with great ceremony. Rohan woke up long enough to eat half of another. Even Meera took one, though she insisted she was not hungry.

We talked for a while about small things: the weather, the long hours of travel, the best chai stalls in the country. But I noticed that nobody asked the one question I badly wanted to ask. Where exactly were we all going?

It was Meera who finally said it.

“The strange part,” she said quietly, “is that I do not remember the last station.”

The laughter faded.

I looked out of the window. The darkness outside was thick and moving. There were no village lights, no signal posts, no passing trains. Only grey fog pressed against the glass like a living thing.

The ceiling lamps flickered once, then twice. Something about the silence changed. It became heavy, almost ominous, like the pause before thunder. Even the sound of the wheels seemed to slow.

Rohan lifted his head from his mother's shoulder. "Mummy, why is it so quiet?"

"Sleep, beta," she whispered. But her voice trembled.

In the eerie yellow light, I noticed that the man in the grey shawl had turned around. He was looking at the ticket in my hand. His face was thin and pale, and there was no expression in it at all.

"May I see yours?" he asked, in a voice like dry paper.

I hesitated, then held it out. He read it, nodded slowly, and from inside his shawl he drew out a ticket of his own. He placed it beside mine.

They were identical. The same yellow card, the same tiny punch hole, the same four words at the bottom: *ANANTPUR ROAD.*

Mr. Fernandes cleared his throat and slowly took out his wallet. Kavita followed. Then Meera, who had stopped smiling and now looked almost afraid. One by one, they laid their tickets on my small tray table.

Five tickets. One destination.

"I thought I was the only one," Meera whispered. "I have been chasing a story about this place for two years. I thought I was the only person in the world who had ever heard its name."

Nobody spoke. The wheels went on, *tak-a-tak*, *tak-a-tak*, and somewhere far ahead the whistle called again, long and low.

Footsteps sounded in the aisle. Mr. Kulkarni walked slowly through the coach, his lantern swaying, his black coat brushing the seats. He stopped beside us, looked at the tickets spread across the tray table, and gave a small, sad smile.

"Anantpur Road in thirty minutes," he said. "Please keep your tickets safe."

He turned to go, then paused.
“You will need them to leave.”

CHAPTER 4

The Ticket Examiner

I could not sit still. The ticking of the wheels, the flicker of the lamps, the five tickets lying on my tray table like cards in a game I did not understand: it all pressed on my chest until I stood up.

"Where are you going?" Meera asked.

"To ask some questions."

"Ask one for me too," she said.

I found Mr. Kulkarni at the far end of the coach, in the narrow space between the two doors. He had hung his lantern on a hook and was gazing through the small window into the fog. For a moment I thought he had not heard me. Then he spoke without turning around.

"You want to know how I knew your name."

"Yes."

"I have known it for a long time." He turned at last, and his eyes, the colour of old tea, were enigmatic, impossible to read. "Your grandfather sat in Seat Forty-One once, forty years ago. He was barely thirty-five and had only just become the station master of Madhavgad. He asked me the same question, standing in the same place."

My throat felt dry. "Dadaji rode this train?"

"Once. A signalman had vanished from his station, and the trail led here. He boarded this train to find him." He paused. "He was one of the few who came back."

"Came back from where?"

"From Anantpur Road."

I pressed my hand against the cold wall of the coach to steady myself. All my life, Dadaji had told me stories about signals and timetables and the great floods of the monsoon. Not once had he mentioned this.

“Who bought my ticket?” I asked. “He could not even walk to the gate.”

“Tickets on this train are never bought, Harsh. They are given.”

“By whom?”

Mr. Kulkarni looked at the lantern, and the small flame leaned toward him as if it were listening. “That depends on who is still waiting.”

It was not an answer, and he knew it. But before I could push him, he nodded toward my pocket.

“You have brought the watch.”

I took it out. In the warm light, the dented brass looked almost alive. “It stopped at 2:47. I do not know why.”

“It stopped when the train last arrived at Anantpur Road. Not before, and not after.” He studied it the way one studies the face of an old friend. “Your grandfather carried it home forty years ago, and it has been waiting ever since.”

“Waiting for what?”

“For you.”

A chill walked down my spine, slow and careful. I wanted to laugh, to say that watches do not wait for anyone, that this was only an old man’s riddle. But the laugh would not come.

“Listen to me carefully,” Mr. Kulkarni said, and his voice dropped. “Where we are going, clocks will lie to you. Doors will lead where you do not expect. Even people will say things that are not quite true. That watch is the only honest clock on the whole line. Keep it close.”

He lifted his lantern from the hook. Above the door, an old round clock with a cracked face read 2:31.

“Sixteen minutes,” he said, and walked away down the aisle, his shadow stretching long behind him.

I stood alone in the swaying space between the coaches. I do not know how long I stayed there. When I finally looked down, I almost dropped the watch.

The hands, frozen at 2:47 for as long as I could remember, had jerked backwards. They now read 2:31, exactly the same as the clock above the door.

And the watch was ticking. Steady, calm and patient, like a heart that had decided to wake up.

CHAPTER 5

2:47 A.M.

When I returned to my seat, the others were awake. Nobody had slept. Mr. Fernandes sat very straight with his hands on his knees. Meera held her pen as if it were a weapon. The man in the grey shawl had not moved at all. Only Rohan was asleep, his cheek pressed against his mother's arm.

Nobody asked where I had been. I did not tell them.

The minutes crawled. I held the watch in my fist and felt each tick travel up my arm. 2:40. 2:43. 2:45. The fog pressed closer to the glass, and for the first time I heard a sound that was not the wheels: a faint, relentless drumming, like fingers tapping on the roof of the train.

"What is that?" Kavita whispered.

"Rain," said Meera.

"It is not raining," Mr. Fernandes said quietly.

At 2:46, the lamps overhead dimmed to a deep amber. A feeling of foreboding settled over the coach, so heavy that I could almost taste it, like metal on my tongue. The drumming stopped.

Then came the brakes. A long, tired sigh rose from the wheels, and the whole coach leaned forward. The five tickets slid off the tray table. Rohan woke with a small cry. Outside, the fog tore apart like old cloth, and a single green lamp swung into view, hanging from a pole at the edge of a platform.

The watch gave one final, loud tick.

2:47.

The train stopped. There was no jolt and no shudder, only a silence so deep that I could hear my own pulse.

With a soft hiss, every door in Coach S4 slid open by itself.

Nobody moved. Cold air flowed into the coach, smelling of wet stone and old smoke, and with it came the sound of a bell, ringing once, far away.

I leaned toward the window and read the board on the platform. It was black, with white letters, the paint chipped by years of weather.

ANANTPUR ROAD.

"It exists," Meera breathed. "It actually exists."

Mr. Fernandes polished his glasses and put them back on, as if the world might look more reasonable through clean lenses. "A station on no map, at a minute that is on no timetable," he murmured. "There is a number missing from this equation, and I do not like the shape of it."

Mr. Kulkarni appeared at the end of the aisle with his lantern. "Anantpur Road," he announced, in the calm voice of an examiner at any ordinary station. "All passengers with tickets for this station are requested to step down. The train will wait until the lamp turns red."

"And if we stay inside?" Kavita asked. Her arm tightened around Rohan.

"The ticket was issued for the station, not for the seat." His gaze rested on her, not unkind. "I would not stay behind. The train does not like to carry what it did not intend to carry."

It was the strangest threat I had ever heard, and the gentlest.

Meera stood first. She slipped her notebook into her jacket and walked to the door without looking back. "If I write nothing else in my life," she said, "I will write this."

The silent man in the grey shawl followed. Then Mr. Fernandes, muttering something about the dignity of mathematics. Kavita rose slowly with Rohan in her arms.

I was the last. I picked up my bag, checked the tickets in my wallet, and stepped down onto the platform of a station that did not exist.

The stone was cold through my shoes. The air was perfectly still. Above us, the green lamp swayed on its pole, though there was no wind.

I turned to look at the train.

Every window had gone dark. The yellow light that had comforted me for hours had vanished, and the long green coaches stood black and silent. Only the lantern in Mr. Kulkarni's hand still glowed, a small gold flame at the open door.

"Welcome to Anantpur Road," he said softly. "Please do not wander far."

Behind him, in the dark carriage, a curtain stirred, though every window was shut.

CHAPTER 6

Anantpur Road

The station was small. That was my first surprise. I had imagined that a place with such a mystery would be vast, with towers and walls. Instead, Anantpur Road was a single stone platform, perhaps two hundred steps long, with a tin roof, a waiting room at one end, and a tea stall at the other. Beyond the edge of the platform, the fog stood like a wall. We could see nothing past the rails.

It was also desolate in a way I had never seen. There were no posters, no vendors, no rubbish, and no footprints. The benches were polished smooth by use, yet there was no dust on them, as if someone cleaned them every morning for passengers who never came.

“There is no sound,” Kavita said. “Not even insects.”

She was right. Even the crickets that sing beside every railway track in India were missing. The silence pressed against our ears.

Meera pointed upward. “Look at the clock.”

A big, round station clock hung from the roof beam, with a white face and black numerals. Both hands stood at 2:47.

“It has stopped,” said Mr. Fernandes. “That is natural. Clocks stop.”

“Check yours,” Meera said.

He looked at his wristwatch and frowned. Kavita checked her phone and found the screen frozen at 2:47. Meera’s watch showed the same. The silent man in the grey shawl lifted his

sleeve and showed us an old steel watch, its second hand motionless. 2:47.

Everything had stopped except the watch in my pocket, which ticked on steadily, as if nothing were wrong.

“Mr. Kulkarni said…” I began, and stopped. I did not know how to explain it. “Mine still works.”

They looked at me for a long moment. Nobody asked why.

We walked together toward the tea stall, partly because it was the only sign of life and partly because nobody wanted to be alone. It was a small wooden counter with a faded canvas awning. A black kettle sat on a clay stove. I reached out and touched it, then pulled my hand back at once.

“It is warm,” I said.

Meera touched it too. “It is hot.” She looked at us. “Someone made this tea minutes ago.”

On the counter stood a row of steel glasses, with a thin curl of steam rising from each. Mr. Fernandes counted them aloud, his voice careful. “One, two, three, four, five, six.”

“Six glasses,” said Kavita.

“Six of us,” Mr. Fernandes said. “Whoever laid these out knew exactly who was coming.”

A thin wind drifted along the platform, smelling of cold iron and incense. There was a melancholy in this place that I could not explain, a deep, quiet sadness, as if the station itself were grieving for something it could not name. It reminded me of the evening of the funeral, when the river had kept talking to itself.

Rohan tugged at his mother’s sari. “Mummy, I am thirsty.”

“No,” she said sharply. “Do not drink anything here.”

The silent man in the shawl spoke for the first time since we had boarded, in a voice like paper being folded. “She is right. Whatever is offered at Anantpur Road has a price.”

“How do you know that?” Meera demanded.

He did not answer. He only looked toward the end of the platform, where the fog was thinnest, and said nothing more.

That was when the loudspeaker woke.

It crackled once above our heads, an old brass horn fixed to the roof beam. Then came a long hiss, the sound of a very old recording being played for the first time in years. We all looked up.

A voice spoke, slow and tired and warm. It was a voice I had known for twenty years. It had read me stories in the evenings, and called me to dinner, and answered every question I had ever asked about trains.

“Right on time.”

My knees gave way. I caught the edge of the counter before I fell.

It was Dadaji.

CHAPTER 7

Dadaji's Letter

Nobody told me it was a trick. I wished that someone would. Meera put a hand on my shoulder, and Mr. Fernandes offered me his handkerchief, but I waved them away and walked to the far end of the platform, where the lamplight did not reach. I needed to be alone with my breathing.

When I closed my eyes, I saw Dadaji at Platform 9 of Madhavgad Junction, years ago, on a night when I was no more than eight. He had taken me with him on one of his long walks, and he had stopped at the very end of the old platform and stared at the empty track. "What are you waiting for?" I had asked. "Is a train coming?" He had smiled, a little sadly, and said, "Not this year, beta." I had not understood him then. I understood a little more now.

In my bag was the bundle of letters from his trunk. I had not been able to leave it behind. I untied the faded red thread with shaking fingers. There were seven envelopes, all yellowed, all addressed in the same slanting hand. Only one was marked *To the one who follows.*

I opened it under the green lamp. Inside was a single sheet covered in blue ink. It was futile to pretend that my hands were steady.

My dear Harsh,

If you are reading this, the watch has found you, and I could not finish what I began. Forgive an old man for leaving you a riddle instead of an answer. Some truths do not survive being spoken aloud.

Forty years ago, I boarded the Night Express to search for a missing signalman. I found Anantpur Road instead. I will not describe what I saw. I will only say that I came home with this watch and a debt I never managed to repay.

You will want to trust the people around you. Some of them deserve it. But do not trust the clocks, the doors, or any voice that sounds kind. Trust the watch. In forty years, it has never lied to me.

There is a register in the waiting room. Read it before dawn, if there is a dawn. And whatever you read, do not believe the last page.

I am proud of you. I always was. Right on time, my boy.

Dadaji

I read it three times, until the words blurred. Then I folded the page, and something on the back caught the green light. There was a line there, written in faint pencil, so light that I would have missed it if I had not turned the paper.

Do not be here when the lamp turns red.

I looked up. The green lamp swayed gently above me, the same colour as before. For now.

"Harsh!"

Meera's voice rang from the waiting room, sharp and strained. I ran toward it, the letter crushed in my hand, and found her standing at an old wooden desk beside the door. On the desk lay a thick, dusty book bound in black cloth.

"It is the station register," she said. Her face had gone pale. "And the handwriting in it is your grandfather's."

CHAPTER 8

The Waiting Room

The waiting room was longer than it looked from outside. Two rows of wooden benches ran down its length, polished smooth by travellers who had never really left. A cold iron stove stood in one corner. At the far end hung an oil lamp whose flame did not flicker, and beneath it stood a heavy desk, where Meera now stood guard over the black cloth register.

"Do not open it yet," I said, a little out of breath. "Not until everyone is here."

They came in one by one: Mr. Fernandes first, then Kavita with Rohan asleep again on her shoulder, and last the man in the grey shawl, who chose the bench nearest the door and sat with his hands folded, like a man waiting for a verdict.

I told them everything. I told them about the watch, the trunk, the letter and the voice on the loudspeaker. I even told them about the pencil line on the back of the page. When I finished, nobody spoke for a long time.

It was Mr. Fernandes who broke the silence. He took off his glasses, rubbed his eyes, and said, "Then I think the time has come for honesty. If five strangers receive the same impossible ticket, it is not a coincidence. It is a pattern. And every pattern has a cause."

"What are you saying?" Kavita asked.

"That each of us came here for a reason we have not told the others." He folded his glasses carefully. "I will begin, since I am the oldest. I had a younger brother, Edwin. He was seventeen, as bright as a lamp, and he loved trains. Fifty-three

years ago he took the night express from Madhavgad, and he never arrived anywhere."

His voice was steady, but his hands were not.

"I was meant to go with him. I had an examination the next morning, so I stayed at home to study. Mathematics, you see. I chose a problem over my brother." He swallowed. "I became a teacher so that I could be useful to other people's children. Last month, a ticket arrived at my door. The address on the envelope was in Edwin's handwriting."

Kavita pressed her cheek against Rohan's hair. "My husband was a railway guard. Suresh. Five years ago he left for his night shift on this very line, and he never came home. Rohan was not even born." She drew a shaky breath. "Three weeks ago I found a ticket under our door. I told myself I was only going to look. I knew it was a lie before I finished saying it."

Meera said nothing. She was gripping the edge of the desk so tightly that her knuckles had turned pale.

"And you?" I asked her.

"I told you. I am following a story." Her voice was too even. "That part is true."

"It is not the whole truth," Mr. Fernandes said gently.

"No," she whispered. "It is not."

Before she could say more, Rohan stirred and lifted his head. He rubbed his eyes and pointed at the wall behind the desk. "Mummy, what are those?"

We turned. In the dim lamplight I had not noticed it before: a tall wooden board covered with rows of tiny brass hooks, hundreds of them, climbing almost to the roof. From each hook hung a small paper tag tied with red thread, exactly like the thread around Dadaji's letters. Most of the tags were yellow and brittle with age.

But six tags, near the bottom, were white and fresh.

Mr. Fernandes crossed the room and read them one at a time, his finger hovering just short of the paper. "*Anthony Fernandes. Kavita Patil. Rohan Patil.*" He paused. "*Meera Kamble.*" Another pause. "*Harsh.*"

"That is five," said Kavita.

The sixth tag hung slightly apart from the others. Its ink had faded almost to nothing, and only two letters could still be made out: *B. K.*

Behind me, a bench creaked. The man in the grey shawl had risen to his feet, and for the first time since Madhavgad there was something in his face. It was not fear. It was hunger, the hunger of a man looking at a door he had thought was bricked up for ever.

And Meera Kamble, who had told us only her first name, stared at the letters *B. K.* as if they were a ghost.

CHAPTER 9

The Station Register

"It is time," said Mr. Fernandes. "Whatever is in that book, we will not learn it by fearing it."

We gathered around the desk. Meera put both hands on the black cover, hesitated, and then opened it.

The first page was covered in thin, careful writing, in an ink that had faded to brown. At the top, in capital letters, were three lines:

THE STATION KEEPS WHAT HAS NOT ARRIVED.

A JOURNEY IS COMPLETE ONLY WHEN A WITNESS, CARRYING A TRUE CLOCK, WRITES "ARRIVED" BESIDE THE TRAVELLER'S NAME.

UNTIL THEN, THE TRAVELLER WAITS.

"A true clock," Mr. Fernandes murmured. He looked at me. "Harsh, the watch."

I touched my pocket. It ticked against my fingers like a small, patient heart.

Meera turned the page. The register was ruled into four columns: *Name*, *Departed*, *Arrived*, *Remarks*. Under *Name* ran a long list in many different hands, century after century of ink. Under *Departed*, the same time was written again and again, in every line of every page: 2:47. Under *Arrived*, there was nothing at all. And under *Remarks*, one word returned like the beat of a drum.

Waiting.

The names went on and on: schoolboys, soldiers, a bride, a tea seller, a family of five. Some entries were so old that I could

not read the dates. Others were so recent that the ink still had a faint shine.

Kavita turned pages with trembling fingers, and then her breath stopped.

"*Suresh Patil. Guard. Departed 2:47. Arrived*," she read, and her voice broke. "There is nothing there. *Remarks: Waiting. Asks after his wife.*"

"Is that Papa?" Rohan asked, standing on tiptoe to see.

She could not answer. She only held him tighter.

Mr. Fernandes found his brother's name a few pages later, written in a neat schoolboy hand that was not Edwin's own. "*Edwin Fernandes, seventeen, student. Remarks: Waiting. Counting the stations.*" He gave a small, broken laugh. "He was always good at mathematics. Better than me, in fact."

He was bewildered, I think, by how much it hurt to read it. His glasses had fogged. He took them off and did not put them back.

The pages near the middle of the book were different. The handwriting suddenly turned slanting and familiar, and I felt the room tilt around me.

"That is his," I said. "That is Dadaji's."

One whole night had been written in his hand, in blue ink, with every line as meticulous as a railway timetable. He had recorded every name he found at Anantpur Road forty years ago, each with a short note in the margin. *Frightened. Hungry. Asks for his mother. Refuses the tea.*

At the bottom of one page, I found his own entry.

Raghunath. Station Master, Madhavgad. Departed 2:47. Arrived Madhavgad, 5:10 a.m., carrying one true clock, a gift from the Examiner. Remarks: I leave a debt. I will send the one who follows.

My eyes stung. Forty years ago, my grandfather had sat at this very desk, afraid, and still found the courage to write a promise.

A ribbon marker lay near the back of the book, tucked between the last pages. I knew what it was marking. *Do not believe the last page.* I did not touch it.

Meera had turned a few pages ahead while the rest of us were reading. She stood very still. When she spoke, her voice was barely a whisper.

"Dadaji wrote this one too," she said. "Look."

He had written it in the same blue ink. *Baburao Kamble. Signalman, Madhavgad. Departed 2:47. Arrived, nothing. Remarks: Found him. Cannot bring him back without a true clock. I will return.*

The whole room went quiet.

Meera lifted her head and looked at the man in the grey shawl. He was no longer sitting by the door. He had crossed the room without a sound and now stood a few steps behind her, and in his thin, pale face, I saw something I had not expected to see in this cold place.

Hope, and terror, tangled together.

"You have read my name," said the man in the shawl.

CHAPTER 10

Meera's Truth

Meera turned around slowly. The pen she had been holding fell from her fingers and rolled across the floor, and nobody moved to pick it up.

"Baburao Kamble," she said. "Signalman. Madhavgad. He went missing on the night of the fourth of March, nineteen eighty-six."

The man in the shawl closed his eyes. "Yes."

"How do you know that date?"

"Because for me," he said, "it was last night."

Meera's hands went to her mouth. When she lowered them, her face was wet.

"He was my grandfather," she said, speaking to all of us but looking only at him. "My father was four years old when he vanished. He grew up with a photograph and an empty chair at the table. He never stopped asking where Baburao Kamble had gone. When he died last year, I found a newspaper clipping in his drawer, and a railway ticket stub, punched with a tiny hole. I became a journalist because of that stub." She laughed, a thin, cracked sound. "For two years, I have chased a station that was not on any map. And three weeks ago, a ticket arrived in my letterbox, with the name of that station on it."

She took a step toward him. "I did not tell you, because I did not know how. I thought that if I said it out loud, it would stop being possible."

The old man looked at her for a long time. When he spoke, his voice shook.

"You have your father's chin," he said. "And his stubbornness. I would know that stubborn chin anywhere."

Meera crossed the last distance in a rush and wrapped her arms around him. He stood stiff for a moment, like a man who has forgotten how to be held, and then his hands rose slowly and gripped the back of her jacket. A sound came out of him that I will not forget: an old, deep sob of anguish that had waited forty years for someone to hear it.

I looked away. So did Kavita. Mr. Fernandes quietly wiped his eyes.

When they finally separated, Baburao sat down heavily on the nearest bench, and Meera sat beside him, holding his hand in both of hers as if it might disappear.

"I owe you all an explanation," he said. "I should have spoken earlier. But I have been alone in this place for so long that I have almost forgotten how."

He told us about that night in nineteen eighty-six. He had been the signalman on duty at Madhavgad when the Night Express came through, an hour early, with all its windows glowing yellow. He had gone to the platform to check the signal, and the doors of Coach S4 had been open, as though waiting for him. "I only meant to look inside," he said. "That was my mistake. The train is very good at making you curious."

He had woken at Anantpur Road with a ticket in his pocket and a cup of tea in his hand. He had not drunk it. "I was lucky. I had my wife's voice in my head, telling me never to accept food from strangers." He smiled sadly. "The ones who drink forget why they came. They sit on those benches and they wait, quite peacefully, for a train that never arrives. They are not unhappy. That is the most horrible part."

"The tea," Kavita said. "Six glasses. For us."

“For anyone who is tired enough or sad enough to be tempted.” He looked at Rohan, who was watching him with wide, curious eyes. “I am glad you did not let him drink it.”

I could not hold the question in any longer. “And my grandfather?”

“Raghunath found me on his night,” Baburao said. “He sat beside me on this bench and told me he would not leave without me. I told him he must. The register does not let a waiting traveller write his own arrival, and the only true clock on the line was the Examiner’s, and Mr. Kulkarni was not allowed to give it away.” He glanced at the watch in my hand. “But he gave it to your grandfather anyway, and your grandfather promised to come back with a witness who could finish what he could not.”

He looked at me, and his eyes were kind. “He said the witness would be the one who follows. I think he meant you.”

A hundred questions rose in my throat, but before I could ask even one, the lamp over the desk gave a sudden flutter.

The flame, which had not moved since we entered, bent sideways as if blown by a breath. Outside, through the open door, the green lamp on its pole had changed.

It was no longer green.

It had turned the deep, warm yellow of a dying candle.

CHAPTER 11

The Signal Lamp

"That is not good," said Mr. Kulkarni.

He was standing in the doorway, his lantern lowered, and for the first time since I had met him, he looked like a man who was afraid.

"Yellow means one hour," he said. "The lamp will turn red at dawn. Whoever is still on this platform when it does will not be able to leave."

"You said that the train would wait for us," Mr. Fernandes said sharply.

"It will wait until the red. After that, it will leave, and the station will keep what it has." He looked around the room, and I understood, with a slow, cold feeling, that he had been telling us the truth in pieces. "I have not told you everything. I am sorry. There are rules I cannot break."

I stepped toward him. "Then break them now. Who are you?"

He took off his cap. His hair underneath was white, and his face, in the light of the lantern, looked far older than it had on the platform.

"I was the last station master of Anantpur Road," he said quietly. "Sixty years ago, my younger brother boarded this train. I followed him. At the last page of the register, a kind voice offered me a bargain: sign my name as master of the station, and my brother's name would be erased from the book, and he could go home." His mouth twisted. "I signed. The

station kept my signature and forgot my brother. I have been punching tickets ever since."

Nobody spoke.

"Do not misunderstand me. I am not your enemy. I gave your grandfather the watch because it was the one true clock I could part with. But I am bound. I can check your tickets and I can open the door. I cannot help you more than that." He turned to me, and his voice dropped. "At some point tonight, it will offer you the same bargain. It will sound like someone you love."

A chill ran through me, and then, behind us, the clocks began to move.

It started with the station clock. Through the open door, I saw its long black hand twitch. Then another clock began to tick in the waiting room wall, and another on the platform. One after another, in a rising rush, every stopped clock in Anantpur Road woke and began to run, faster than any clock should, as though making up for lost time.

And with each tick, something went out of the room.

It was subtle at first. Kavita frowned at the child in her arms. "Rohan, what is your school called?" she murmured, and then she shook her head. "No, that is silly. I know that." But she did not. I saw it in her eyes.

Mr. Fernandes stared at his hands. "The quadratic formula," he said slowly. "I have taught it for thirty-five years. It begins with… It begins…" He stopped. His face crumpled in a way I could hardly bear to watch.

"The clocks are taking our memories," Meera said. "Every second that passes, we lose something."

"Yes," said Mr. Kulkarni. "That is how the station keeps travellers. It does not hold them with chains. It lets them forget why they should leave."

A long, low whistle tore through the night.

We all ran to the door. At the far end of the platform, the Night Express was alive. Steam hissed from its wheels, its green coaches shuddered, and with a great groan, it began to roll forward, away from us, into the fog.

Kavita screamed. "Rohan's bag is in there!"

"Sit down!" Mr. Kulkarni's voice cracked like a whip across the platform. "It is only a warning!"

The train rolled perhaps a hundred steps and stopped. The whistle faded. The engine sighed and went quiet. The fog closed around it again.

In the silence that followed, I felt the watch in my pocket burning against my leg. It was the only clock in Anantpur Road that had not changed its pace. It ticked steadily, calmly, as it always had.

I had trepidation in my heart, and a question that I did not want to ask. But I asked it anyway.

"How long do we have?"

Mr. Kulkarni looked up at the yellow lamp. A single thread of grey light was creeping above the fog in the east, so faint that I might have imagined it.

"Less than you would like," he said.

CHAPTER 12

Choices in the Dark

"The register is our only map," Mr. Fernandes said. "We must read it again, more carefully, while we can still remember how."

He was right. We hurried back into the waiting room, and I had just laid my hand on the black cover when the oil lamp, which had burned steadily all night, went out.

Darkness dropped over us like a cloth over a cage. I heard Rohan whimper. I heard Kavita whisper his name again and again, as if it were a rope she was holding on to.

Then, from somewhere beyond the open door, a voice drifted through the fog.

"Kavita?"

It was a man's voice, warm and a little hoarse, the voice of someone who has been calling for a very long time. Kavita went rigid.

"Suresh," she said. "Suresh!" She lunged forward, and I caught her wrist just before she reached the doorway. She fought me. "Let me go! That is my husband!"

"Kavita, listen," Meera said, taking her other arm. "Think. Why would he call from out there instead of walking in?"

"Tony!" cried a second voice, young and bright, from the other side of the platform. "Tony, I have counted all the stations! There are forty-one!"

Mr. Fernandes made a sound that I hope never to hear again. He took one step toward the door, and Baburao wrapped both arms around him from behind. "Do not," he said fiercely.

"I have heard voices like those for forty years. They are not who they sound like."

"That is Edwin," Mr. Fernandes whispered. "I know my brother's voice."

"It knows your brother's voice," said Baburao. "That is not the same thing."

I stood in the dark, holding Kavita's wrist, listening to the two voices call and call, and I felt the watch beating against my leg like a second heart. It was the only steady thing in the world.

Then someone spoke very close to my ear.

"Harsh."

My blood stopped.

I knew that voice. I had heard it that very night, from the loudspeaker. But now it was not distant and crackling. It was warm and clear and just behind my shoulder, exactly the way it had sounded when I was a child falling asleep in the next room.

"Harsh, beta. Come to the desk."

I should have been afraid. Instead, my knees went weak with longing. I let go of Kavita's wrist. Meera said something, but her words seemed to come from the bottom of a well. I walked slowly through the dark until my hand found the edge of the desk. A faint light was rising from the open register, pale and silver, and in it I saw the ribbon marker lying across the last page and a pen beside it, already uncapped.

"I did not want to leave you a riddle," said Dadaji's voice, sad and tender. "Forgive me. I was afraid. I should have told you everything while I could."

"Dadaji," I said. My own voice sounded very small.

"It is simple, my boy. Only your name, here, on the last line. They will all go home on the five-ten, every one of them:

Suresh, Edwin, Baburao, all the forgotten ones. You will keep the station for one night only. One night. And in the morning, I will come and take your place myself."

It was so reasonable, so loving. It was persuasive in the way a warm room is persuasive when you have stood in the cold for hours. I picked up the pen. My hand was shaking. The nib hovered above the paper, a hair's breadth from the ink.

"One night," the voice murmured. "That is all."

And suddenly I thought of something strange. In twenty years of listening to my grandfather, I had never once heard him say "only one night" about anything. He did not deal in small promises. He said *Right on time.* He said *The train will not wait for you, so be early.* He had never asked anyone for anything twice, not a favour, not a debt, not even a cup of tea.

And he had never, ever begged.

Do not trust any voice that sounds kind, he had written.

My fingers tightened on the pen. In my pocket, the watch burned like a coal.

"Dadaji," I said slowly, "you told me not to believe the last page."

The silence that followed was terrible. Then the warmth went out of the voice like a flame being pinched, and what remained was something cold and hollow and sinister, a thing wearing my grandfather's voice like a borrowed coat.

"Then you will lose them all," it said.

"No," I said. I put down the pen. "I think you are the one who is going to lose."

The oil lamp blazed back to life. In its sudden light I saw everyone standing in a ring around the desk, holding hands. Kavita was sobbing with her face in Rohan's hair. Mr. Fernandes was as pale as paper. Baburao and Meera were

gripping both of them with all their strength. The voices outside had stopped.

The register lay open under my hands. The ribbon had slid aside on its own, and the last page was waiting for me, silent and white.

CHAPTER 13

The Last Page

Nobody moved. Nobody breathed. The lamp burned on the desk and the register lay open to its last page, and I knew that whatever was written there, I would have to read it.

"Together," said Meera, and came to stand at my right shoulder. Mr. Fernandes took my left. Behind us, Kavita and Baburao leaned close.

At the top of the page, in tall black letters, was a title.

STATION MASTER OF ANANTPUR ROAD.

Beneath it was a single line in blue ink. The handwriting was slanting, careful and unmistakable, and my heart dropped when I saw that it was my grandfather's.

Appointed at 2:47 a.m.: Harsh.

Beside it, in the margin, was a date.

I read it twice. Then I did the sum. It was a date exactly forty years in the past, the very night that Dadaji had come to Anantpur Road. It was twenty years before I was born.

"It says I was appointed on the night he was here," I said. My throat felt tight. "It says he gave them my name. That he traded me for his way home."

Mr. Kulkarni had come to the door. "That is what it wants you to believe," he said quietly. "It showed me the same page sixty years ago, with my brother's name on it in my own handwriting. I was so heartbroken that I signed to prove it wrong. That is how it keeps its masters."

"Do not believe the last page," Meera murmured. "He told you."

"I know," I said. "I know. But how can I be sure?"

It was Mr. Fernandes who answered. He had put his glasses back on, and for a moment I saw the old teacher in his face, resolute and calm. "By mathematics, my boy. Let us consider the facts. A register records an event only after it has happened, and an event can happen only in time. Is that correct?"

"Yes," I said slowly.

"Then how can a register written at a stopped clock, at a minute that never ends, contain an entry dated twenty years before you existed?" He tapped the page. "It cannot. This is not a record. It is a forecast, and a forged one."

Something eased in my chest. I let out a breath that seemed to have been trapped inside me since the funeral. "A forgery."

"A trap," said Baburao. "A very old one."

I looked down at the watch in my hand. It ticked calmly against my palm, as it had ticked for hours, indifferent to everything. *The only honest clock on the line*, Mr. Kulkarni had said. *The only true clock.*

"Wait," I said. "The rule on the first page. A journey is complete only when a witness with a true clock writes ARRIVED." I flipped back through the register, my fingers clumsy on the heavy pages. "There are hundreds of names. Thousands. We cannot write beside every one of them before dawn."

"No," said Meera, "but look."

She had gone back to the very first page, past the three lines of rules. In the margin, so faint that every one of us had missed it, a single line was written in a thin, ancient hand.

Night Express, Coach S4. Departed 2:47. Arrived: nothing. Remarks: Waiting for its witness.

"The train," said Mr. Kulkarni softly. He had come to the desk, and he was staring at that line as if he had never seen it before. "In sixty years, I never looked at the margin. Every traveller in this book came on that one train. Their journeys are all part of its journey."

"Then if its journey ends," said Mr. Fernandes slowly, "theirs end with it."

"One line," I said. "One witness. One true clock."

"And a time of arrival," said Baburao, "that is not 2:47."

I stared at him. "What do you mean?"

"Every entry in this book says 2:47, because here it is always 2:47. That is how it holds us. A man cannot arrive at a time that never comes." His eyes held mine. "Someone has to write the next minute. Someone has to make time move."

Through the window, the yellow lamp flickered and then shifted to an angry orange. Above the fog, the grey thread of dawn had widened into a pale gold band.

"Minutes," said Mr. Kulkarni. "Not hours."

I looked at their faces: Kavita holding Rohan, Mr. Fernandes with his brother's name still on his lips, Meera and her grandfather, and the old examiner who had waited sixty years for someone to read a margin.

My hands had stopped shaking.

I picked up the pen.

CHAPTER 14

The Minute That Moved

The nib touched the paper, and the whole station screamed.

It was not a human sound. It was the shriek of a thousand clocks being forced to tell the truth, and it came from the walls, the roof, the rails, the fog itself. The oil lamp swung wildly. The benches rattled. On the shelf behind the desk, the steel glasses of tea that someone had carried in from the stall shattered one by one and spilled across the floor.

I wrote the first letters on the line beside the train's name, and the ink fought me. It crawled sideways. It dried before the pen could move. The first letter came out as a blot, and the blot sprouted wet black roots that crept up the page toward my fingers.

"Hold the register!" Mr. Kulkarni shouted. Baburao and Meera threw their weight against the desk. Mr. Fernandes gripped one side of the page and Kavita the other, with Rohan's small hands pressed flat beside hers.

The voice came again, no longer warm. It came from everywhere, a roaring, hollow thing. *You will forget. You will forget your name. You will forget your mother. You will forget why you came.*

And it began.

Something slid out of my mind like water through my fingers. I saw Aai's face at the gate, and then I did not see it. I knew that there had been a woman who pressed warm chapatis into my hands, but I could not tell what she looked like

or what she called me. I stared at the pen and the page, and for one horrible moment I could not remember what I was doing.

"Harsh!" Meera cried.

I looked down. The watch lay beside the register where I had set it. It was ticking, tick, tick, tick, small and stubborn, a sound that did not belong in this place. My eyes found the engraving on its back.

For the one who follows.

And everything came back in a rush: Dadaji on the veranda saying *Right on time*; the sharp corners of his folded uniform; Aai's hand on my cheek and her voice saying *Ask where it leads.* I knew where it led.

It led here. To this line, this pen, this minute.

I pressed the nib into the paper and wrote, in letters as large and steady as a station sign:

ARRIVED.

The letters blazed. Then, under the heading *Time*, I wrote the number that nobody in this place had written for decades.

2:48.

For one heartbeat, nothing happened. Then every clock in Anantpur Road struck at once.

The sound was enormous and clean, as if forty years of silence were being rung out of a single bell. The station clock on the roof beam jumped forward one tick. The clock above the desk jumped with it. The lamp over our heads steadied and burned a clear gold. And outside, over the fog, the sky split open from east to west and let in the first true light I had seen all night.

The register glowed. It was luminous, a soft white radiance that poured off the pages and ran along the floor in rivers, out

of the door and down the platform. Wherever it touched, the fog melted.

"Look," Kavita whispered.

Out of the thinning mist, shapes were walking toward us.

They came in ones and twos at first, then in dozens, then in hundreds: the forsaken travellers of Anantpur Road, blinking and bewildered, with the faint taste of the sweet old tea still on their lips. Schoolboys with satchels. A soldier in a faded uniform. A bride in red, still holding her bouquet. A tea seller wiping his hands on his apron. A family of five, holding hands. They walked out of oblivion, out of forty years, a hundred years, more than that, and they walked toward the train, whose windows were blazing yellow again.

Kavita's cry cracked the air.

A man in a railway guard's uniform was coming along the platform with a lantern in his hand, his face thin and tired and wonderfully alive. He had stopped and was staring at the woman and the boy at the waiting room door, as if he could not decide whether they were real.

"Suresh," Kavita said, and then she was running, and Rohan was running beside her, and Suresh dropped the lantern and caught them both.

Nearby, Mr. Fernandes had fallen to his knees on the platform. A tall, bright-eyed boy of seventeen stood in front of him with a school bag over one shoulder, looking down at the white-haired old man with open amazement.

"Tony?" said Edwin. "You got so old."

Mr. Fernandes laughed, a wet, broken laugh, and put his arms around his little brother and held on.

I turned to Baburao and Meera, but I did not need to. Meera had her grandfather's hand pressed against her cheek, and he

was looking at the dawn with the expression of a man who had forgotten that the sky was so large.

There was only one name left in my mind. I looked at Mr. Kulkarni.

He stood in the middle of the glowing floor with his lantern lowered, quite still. “My brother’s name was Vishwas,” he said, very quietly, as if he were afraid of the sound. “Vishwas Kulkarni. He was eleven.”

I took up the pen again. *Vishwas Kulkarni*, I wrote, and beside it, *ARRIVED*, and the time. The ink did not fight me now.

Out on the platform, a small boy in a school uniform stepped out of the last wisp of fog, looked around him, and began to run.

I will not describe the next minute. Some things belong only to the people they happen to. I will only say that when the old examiner turned back to me, there was nothing hidden in his face any more. It was open and wet and sixty years younger than it had been.

He pressed his brass lantern into my hands.

“The station has no master now,” he said. “There is no one left to keep. And you, young man, were the one who followed.”

He clasped my hand once, tightly, and went to his brother.

Behind him, the orange lamp on its pole slid with a small click to red.

“Everyone aboard!” I shouted. “Now!”

CHAPTER 15

Right on Time

We boarded the Night Express as the sun rose.

It was not the same train. The coaches were still deep green, but the windows were bright, the brass handles had a warm shine, and the whole thing smelled of ordinary things: hot tea, old leather, someone's tiffin of rice and pickle. Hundreds of people filled its seats, laughing, crying and calling out to one another in a dozen languages. Nobody checked a single ticket.

I stood at the open door of Coach S4 as Anantpur Road dissolved behind us. The tin roof thinned like mist. The black signboard faded letter by letter until only the last two remained, hanging over empty rails. Then those were gone too, and there was only the plain, flat, golden land of morning, with a few cranes crossing the sky.

"It was never really a place," said Baburao beside me. He had given up his grey shawl, and he looked younger without it. "It was a minute that all of us agreed to stop. A sanctuary that had forgotten how to open its doors."

I did not think I fully understood, but I did not argue.

Meera came to the door too, with her notebook in her hand. For a long time she did not open it.

"I thought I would write the biggest story of my life," she said at last. "But some stories are not for newspapers." She tucked the notebook away, smiled at her grandfather, and reached for his hand. "Besides, I have better material now. I have forty years of family history to catch up on."

The train pulled into Madhavgad Junction at ten minutes past five, exactly as it had once done for my grandfather.

Platform 9 was crowded with morning mist and the smell of coal smoke and wet stone. The old tin roof was still rusted, the stairs still creaked, and the stray dog under the broken bench lifted his head and wagged his tail, as if greeting an old friend.

There was one person on the platform.

Aai stood at the edge of the stone with a steel tiffin in her hands, wearing the same dupatta she had worn to the funeral. She did not call out. She did not run. She simply watched as I stepped down from the train, and I saw her eyes fill and overflow.

"Aai," I said.

"You are right on time," she said. Her voice shook. "Your Dadaji told me to be here at dawn, three days before he died. He said, 'Do not ask me how. Just be on Platform 9 when the sun comes up, with something warm for the boy.'" She laughed through her tears and held out the tiffin. "He never mentioned the other six hundred."

I threw my arms around her, tiffin and all.

Behind us, a poignant chorus rose from the train. Kavita's laughter. Rohan's shout of delight at seeing the great steam-blackened engine up close. Suresh's deep voice calling his son's name, as if he were trying it for the first time. Mr. Fernandes, sitting on a bench with an arm around his little brother, explaining the quadratic formula to a bewildered seventeen-year-old in the same patient voice he had used for thirty-five years. Mr. Kulkarni and a small boy in a school uniform, looking up together at the station clock.

The clock read 5:10. It was ticking.

When the crowd had thinned, I sat on the old bench under the broken roof and took out the brass watch. It was warm in my hand, as if someone had been holding it. The hands moved calmly forward through the morning. I turned it over, expecting nothing, and read the words on the back.

They had changed.

For the one who arrived.

I do not know how long I sat there. The sun climbed. The platform filled with ordinary noise. Porters in red shirts hurried past with luggage balanced on their heads, and a chai seller called, “Garam chai, garam chai!”, and for once I did not feel the cold at all.

I closed my hand over the watch and looked up at the empty rails of Platform 9, where my grandfather had stood one night every year, waiting for a train that would not come.

“Right on time, Dadaji,” I said.

Behind me, for just a moment, I could almost hear him laugh.

THE END

Glossary of Hard Words

Difficult words used in the story, with their meanings.

Solemn: serious and quiet, especially at an important or sad moment.

Cryptic: having a hidden or mysterious meaning that is hard to understand.

Bustling: full of busy, noisy activity.

Weary: very tired, in body or mind.

Dilapidated: old, broken down, and in very poor condition.

Vestige: a small trace or sign of something that once existed.

Ominous: giving a feeling that something bad is about to happen.

Eerie: strange and frightening in a quiet, mysterious way.

Enigmatic: mysterious and hard to understand or read.

Relentless: never stopping or easing.

Foreboding: a strong feeling that something bad will happen.

Desolate: empty, lonely, and without life.

Melancholy: a deep, quiet sadness.

Futile: having no chance of success; pointless.

Meticulous: extremely careful and exact about small details.

Bewildered: very confused and puzzled.

Anguish: severe pain or sorrow of the mind.

Trepidation: a feeling of fear about something that may happen.

Persuasive: good at making someone believe or do something.

Sinister: seeming evil or harmful.

Resolute: firm and determined, not giving up.

Oblivion: the state of being completely forgotten.

Luminous: giving off light; glowing.

Forsaken: abandoned and left alone.

Poignant: causing a deep feeling of sadness or tender emotion.

Sanctuary: a safe place of shelter.